

The Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Few Syllables

Āryasvalpaakṣaraprajñāpāramitā nāma mahāyānasūtra · Toh 22 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཤེས་རབ་ཀྱི་རྒྱ་མཚན་པ་ཡི་གེ་ཉེ་དུ་རྒྱུ་བ་བྱ་ཐབས་ཀྱི་ཐུགས་སྒྲུབ་པའི་མཛད་སྒོ།

Toh 22 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Āryasvalpaakṣaraprajñāpāramitā and in Tibetan as the Phags pa shes rab kyi pha rol tu phyin pa yi ge nyung ngu, meaning in English the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Few Syllables. As its name suggests, it is a brief prajñāpāramitā scripture — one of the shorter texts belonging to the Perfection of Wisdom class — that distills the essence of the vast prajñāpāramitā literature into a compact teaching on the nature of emptiness and awakening. The sūtra opens with the Buddha residing on Vulture Peak in Rājagṛha, where the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara rises to deliver its core instruction. It belongs to the Perfection of Wisdom section of the Kangyur, standing within a rich tradition of sūtras that range from enormously expansive to highly condensed formulations of the same profound insight.

In the language of India: Āryā Svalpaakṣara Prajñāpāramitā Nāma Mahāyāna Sūtra.

In the language of Tibet: The Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Few Syllables — a Sūtra of the Great Vehicle.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling in Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak Mountain, together with a great Saṅgha of twelve thousand five hundred monks, and with many tens of millions upon hundreds of millions of bodhisattvas. He was surrounded by gods beyond counting — Śakra (Indra, king of the gods), Brahmā, the protectors of the world, and others — who gazed upon him from the front. And there he sat upon a lion throne at the heart of glory.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara rose from his seat, drew his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee upon the ground, turned to face the Blessed One, and with palms joined in reverence he bowed, smiling, and addressed the Blessed One with these words.

Blessed One, I beg you to speak of the great merit of the Perfection of Wisdom in Few Syllables — the merit by which the mere hearing of it purifies all karmic obscurations of all sentient beings, decisively inclines them toward awakening,

and enables all those who strive in the practice of secret mantra to accomplish their mantra practice without obstacles.

Then the Blessed One spoke words of approval to the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara, saying: Excellent, excellent! Noble son, it is well that for so long you have striven for the benefit of all sentient beings. Therefore, noble son, listen carefully and hold it in your mind, for I shall explain to you the Perfection of Wisdom in Few Syllables — with its great merit — by the mere hearing of which all karmic obscurations of all sentient beings are purified, they become decisively inclined toward awakening, and all those who strive in the practice of secret mantra accomplish their mantra practice without obstacles.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara said again to the Blessed One: I beg you to speak it for the sake of healing all sentient beings.

Then the Blessed One, at that very moment, entered into the meditative absorption called Liberation of All Sentient Beings. From the very state of that equipoise, many hundreds of thousands of rays of light burst forth from the space between his brows. Those rays of light pervaded all buddha fields everywhere. All sentient beings touched by those rays of light — down to the beings in the hells — every single one of them became definitively destined for unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. All the buddha fields throughout the ten directions trembled in six ways. A rain of divine sandalwood powder fell before the feet of the Tathāgata.

Then the Blessed One, at that very moment, spoke this Perfection of Wisdom.

The bodhisattva should cultivate a mind of equanimity, a mind of loving-kindness, a mind that repays kindness, and a mind free from all evil. And this heart of the Perfection of Wisdom is to be recited:

Homage to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha Śākyamuni.

Tadyathā — oṃ mune mune mahāmunaye svāhā.

Through my finding this Perfection of Wisdom, I have attained unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. All buddhas, too, have arisen from this. It is from the great Tathāgata Śākyamuni himself that you have received this very thing. Therefore you have become supreme among bodhisattvas, great beings.

You shall become the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha known as Glorious Heap of Rays of Light, the Exalted King — and thus a prophecy of your own buddhahood was given as well. All those who hear your name, hold it, recite it, extensively teach it to others, and write it in a book and venerate it — every single one of them will, in a future time, become a Tathāgata.

Tadyathā — jaya jaya padmābhe avame sara saraṇi nghiri dhiri dhiri dhiri devatānupālāne buddha uttaraṇi pūraya bhagavati sarvā śama śama sarvasattvānāṃ sarvakarma āvaraṇa viśodhaya buddhe adhiṣṭhānena svāhā.

In the ultimate sense, this Perfection of Wisdom is that which gives birth to all buddhas, the mother of the bodhisattvas that instantly strips away evil, and that which bestows awakening. Indeed, even if all the buddhas were to speak of its qualities for ten billion eons, they would not be able to exhaust them. By reciting this, one will receive empowerment into all maṇḍalas, and all secret mantras will become fully manifest.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, why is this called the Perfection of Wisdom?"

The Blessed One declared: "It is because the method is easy. Those sentient beings who have little enthusiasm — all of them, through holding, reciting, transcribing, and causing others to transcribe this Perfection of Wisdom, will through this easy method turn toward awakening. That is why it is called the Perfection of Wisdom."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how wondrous it is that you have proclaimed this teaching for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the benefit of sentient beings of little merit, and for their healing and happiness. Blessed One, how wondrous! Sugata, how wondrous!"

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara, those monks, those bodhisattvas, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas all rejoiced, and praised what the Blessed One had proclaimed.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase "repays kindness" renders the Tibetan expression for gratitude toward those who have been kind, a traditional virtue in Mahāyāna ethics. Some editions may vary slightly in the

framing of these four mental qualities attributed to the bodhisattva.

The closing declaration — "Through my finding this Perfection of Wisdom, I have attained unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening" — appears to be spoken in the voice of the buddha (or of the teaching itself), following the convention of this sūtra type in which the text's own power is proclaimed. The transition from the Blessed One's direct speech to this first-person voice is abrupt in the Tibetan and may reflect a compressed sūtra format.

- The buddha-name རྒྱལ་པོ་རྣམ་འབྲས་ཀྱི་ཡུལ་ལྷན་གྱི་ཕོ་ཉལ་ཆོས་ཀྱི་འཛེག་པོ་ is a compound of several epithets meaning "rays of light rising fully, glorious heap, king." The rendering "Glorious Heap of Rays of Light, the Exalted King" follows the literal Tibetan; no Sanskrit equivalent is preserved in the manuscript tradition for this particular prophecy name, so no Sanskrit has been supplied.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.